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THE VOYAGE OF THE KESTREL

A Tale of the Sea



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THE VOYAGE OF THE KESTREL

A Tale of the Sea

Arthur Marcet, a cartographer’s apprentice, must find out where the silk chart leads, and who else wants to get there first. An original adventure in five chapters.

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A Note from the Publisher

The great adventure stories begin with a map and end with a homecoming, and in between they ask what people are really made of. *The Voyage of the Kestrel* follows Arthur from a dull office desk to Varra Sound, a coast of fjords and glaciers in the cold northern seas beyond the whaling grounds, and back again — changed.

It was written for this edition as a tribute to the sea stories and expedition tales of the nineteenth century, the same tradition preserved in the public domain library behind GetFreeEbooks.

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First Edition, 2026

A note on process: this story was planned and written by offline software, using story patterns modelled on public domain fiction, then reviewed before publication.

Acknowledgements

This story owes its shape to the storytellers of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, whose public domain novels and tales set the patterns it follows — and to the volunteers who digitised and preserved that work so it can still be read today.

This book is published through GetFreeEbooks, a platform built on a simple idea: that good books should be easy to find, and free to read. Thank you to that community of readers and writers for giving books like this one a place to land.

Chapter 1: An Offer

It began, as the worst and best things in Arthur Marcet's life were to begin, with a summons to the owners' office. He was a cartographer's apprentice, and he had spent three years at a high desk looking out at other people's ships. Now he stood before a long table in a room full of cigar smoke, and a man he had never seen before was telling him about the voyage. He was to be sent to chart what the old maps left blank.

The clerk laid a chart painted on a square of oiled silk on the table. It was no bigger than a handkerchief, its colours still bright after heaven knew how many years, and everyone in the room leaned forward. In one corner, in faded ink, someone had written a single name: Varra Sound. Arthur looked at it and felt something turn over in his chest, like a key in a lock that has not been used for a long time.

"You'll sail with Matthew Mannering," said the owner, and a man who had been sitting unnoticed in the corner got up. He was a lean, sun-browned man who wrote in a notebook even while eating. He studied the silk chart for some minutes without touching it, and Arthur, watching his face, had the odd impression that he was not seeing it for the first time.

"Have you ever been to sea?" asked Mr Mannering.

"Only on the ferry."

"Good. You'll have nothing to unlearn." Mr Mannering rolled up the silk chart and handed it to Arthur. "Keep this. Don't show it to anyone. And if anyone asks you what we're after — anyone at all, mind — you tell them we're after birds."

It was on the quay, the night before they sailed, that Arthur first met Owen Garside. He was the first mate: a handsome, easy man whom the crew would follow anywhere. He shook Arthur's hand warmly and called him by his first name at once, and asked a great many friendly questions — none of which, Arthur noticed afterwards, had been about birds.

Chapter 2: Nine Days Out

The Kestrel cleared the river on the morning tide and stood out to sea, and for Arthur the world became very simple: the ship, the sky, the long hills of the water, and his own stomach, which betrayed him for three days together. On the fourth day he woke and found that he was hungry, and that the sea, which had been an enemy, had become merely enormous.

In the evenings, when the watch was set and the ship settled into her long easy roll, Arthur would sit on the hatch cover and watch the sun go down into the sea. He had never seen so much sky. The men sang sometimes, forward, in voices roughened by salt, and Arthur would listen and feel that he had been at sea all his life, and had only now noticed it.

At the last port they took aboard Francis Conrad, who had sailed with Mr Mannering on his first voyage to Varra Sound and was the only other man to come home from it. He was a gaunt, grey man who flinched whenever the place was named, and he would not speak of it. Mr Mannering had said to show the chart to no one, but Conrad, of all men, had seen it before. When Arthur showed it to him, he looked at it in silence, and then touched one corner of it, very gently, as one might touch the hand of someone dead.

On the ninth day the weather turned. The glass fell all morning, and by noon a full gale was blowing out of a black sky. For two nights nobody slept. A sea came aboard and carried away the spare spars and half the bulwarks; a man went over the side and was hauled back by the hair. Arthur worked the pumps until his hands bled, and at the worst of it, looking up, saw Mr Garside standing quite still by the mainmast, watching Mr Mannering with a very curious expression.

Land came up out of the sea on a pale morning at the end of the northern summer, when the nights were drawing in again, exactly where the silk chart had said it would. Ahead of them lay the mouth of the sound, a mile wide between black cliffs, with the white tongue of a glacier shining far up at its head. The crew lined the rail in silence. Mr Conrad made a sign with his hand that Arthur did not recognise. And Mr Mannering, standing beside Arthur, said something under his breath that might have been a name.

Chapter 3: Varra Sound

Arthur was on deck before sunrise. The Kestrel lay at anchor in the first light, with Varra Sound close enough now to smell. The sea was flat and grey as slate under a low sky. Mr Conrad was already at the rail, and Mr Mannering stood beside him, looking at the shore and saying nothing. Arthur went to join them, and wondered what the day would bring.

Mr Mannering, Mr Garside, Mr Conrad, Arthur and four hands went ashore in the gig, and the land received them with the wind moaning across the heath. Everything was strange. They passed the skeleton of a whale, bleached white, lying where the tide had left it, and beyond it moss so thick that a man sank to his ankles in it. Arthur carried the silk chart in an oilskin inside his shirt, and every so often he put his hand to it, the way a gambler touches a lucky coin.

It was Arthur who found the way. He had been studying the silk chart for days, and he had an instinct for the lie of the land. That, as much as luck, made him see what the others had missed: that the line on the chart was not a coast at all, but a path, and that it ran up through the head of the sound and down into a gorge beyond it. Mr Mannering studied it without a word. “Well done,” he said at last, and it was the first time he had ever said it.

That night, at the fire, Arthur said it aloud. “You’ve been here before.”

Mr Mannering did not deny it. He sat looking into the fire. “Once,” he said at last. “A long time ago. I was younger than you are now.”

“What happened?”

“I came back,” said Mr Mannering. “That’s all you need to know tonight.”

On the third day they found the first sign that others had come before them: an iron ring driven into the rock, rusted almost through, and beside it, cut into the stone, a name and a date. Mr Conrad would go no further that day. Mr Mannering stood before the carving with his hat in his hand. And Mr Garside, when he thought no one was looking, copied the name carefully into a notebook of his own.

Arthur walked along the shore in the afternoon while the others rested. He passed a whaling station long abandoned, its try-pots red with rust, and all the way he could hear the cry of the kittiwakes on the cliffs. Once he stopped and looked back and thought he saw someone standing on the ridge above the camp, watching — but at that distance he could not have said who it was, and when he looked again the ridge was empty.

That night Arthur lay awake listening to the crack and boom of the glacier calving. The fire had burned down. Somewhere out in the dark something moved, and stopped, and moved again. He put his hand on the silk chart, and it was still there, and towards dawn he slept. He did not see Mr Garside rise, very quietly, and go down towards the shore.

Chapter 4: The Long Night

In the morning the gig was gone, and Mr Garside with it, and the four hands he had talked round in the night. So were half the stores, and the rifles, and Mr Mannering's sextant. They found the tracks of the keel on the sand, and a few cables off, so near that they could see the men at the rail, the Kestrel, with the crew Mr Garside had turned working her out towards the mouth of the sound.

The storm came that same night. They had no shelter but the rocks, no fire but what they could coax from wet driftwood. All night a gale came roaring down off the ice cap, and the water of the sound was torn white from shore to shore. Mr Mannering said nothing at all. He sat with his back to the stone and his eyes shut, and when Arthur asked if he was ill, he only said, "It was just like this, the last time."

In the cold hour after the storm Arthur came very near to giving up. They had no boat, no stores, no way home. He was more tired than he had ever been, and the tiredness sat on him like a hand on his shoulder. It would have been so easy to sit down on the rocks and wait. But Mr Mannering was watching him, and something in his face — not hope, exactly, but a kind of stubborn patience — made him get up again.

So they went on — Arthur leading now, with the silk chart in his hand, and Mr Conrad beside him, and Mr Mannering coming last, slowly, as though every step cost him something. They climbed through the head of the sound, past a beach of round grey stones that clattered underfoot, and out at last onto a high bare place where the wind came clean off the sea and there was nothing ahead but the sky. Below them, on the far side, a gorge fell steeply to a strip of shingle, and the tide was already creeping in across it.

Chapter 5: The Last Entry

They found it at the bottom of the gorge, where the silk chart had said: a chest, iron-bound, half sunk in the gravel. It took all of them to drag it clear. And it was while they were straining at it, too spent to look up, that a voice above them said, “Leave it — for God’s sake, leave it and get up here — the tide’s coming in,” and they looked up and saw Mr Garside, alone, soaked to the skin, with a rope in his hands.

Mr Garside told them the rest while they hauled the chest up out of the tide’s reach. He had sold them to the crew he had turned, and he did not pretend otherwise; it had been he on the ridge that first afternoon, marking the way. But those men had meant to leave no witnesses, and somewhere in the night Mr Garside had found that he could not stomach it. While the Kestrel lay storm-bound at the mouth of the sound he had slipped over the side, swum ashore, and come back along the cliffs to find them. “Don’t thank me,” he said. “I don’t know that I’d do it twice.”

“You’ll write this up, I suppose,” Mr Mannering said to Arthur. “In that neat hand of yours.”

“If you’ll let me,” said Arthur.

“Write it true, then. All of it. Don’t make heroes of any of us.” Mr Mannering looked out at the sea. “We weren’t. We were just the ones who came.”

They were taken off by a trading schooner that put into the sound for water, and the chest came with them. It held less than anyone had dreamed and more than any of them had ever owned. Arthur, Mr Mannering and Mr Conrad shared it equally among the three of them; Mr Garside would not touch a coin of it. At the first port Mr Garside was gone, off the schooner without a word. Arthur often thought about him afterwards. He never decided whether Mr Garside had been a bad man who did one good thing, or a good man who had taken a long time to find out.

Many years later Arthur wrote it all down, as Mr Mannering had asked — true, and all of it, and no heroes. It was never published. It lay in a drawer until he died, with the silk chart folded inside the first page. And on the last page, in his small neat hand, he had written only this: *We were just the ones who came.*

Behind the Story

The Voyage of the Kestrel was built for GetFreeEbooks by an offline story engine. Instead of copying any single book, it combines story ingredients modelled on classic adventure fiction — a setting, a cast of archetypes, an incident, a set of clues and a twist. It then renders them through a hand-written template grammar.

This story's ingredients: Varra Sound (coast of fjords and glaciers, the cold northern seas beyond the whaling grounds); Arthur Marcet, a cartographer's apprentice; a chart painted on a square of oiled silk.

The characters' surnames are drawn from the public domain library behind this imprint, filtered so that no well-known character's name is reused. The pacing — how much of the story is carried by dialogue — follows the median of the 380 stories and chapters on that library's adventure shelf.

Story seed: **3**.

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